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80 GLORIOUS YEARS OF VIVEKANANDA COLLEGE

Alumni recall their long association with the college **P2**



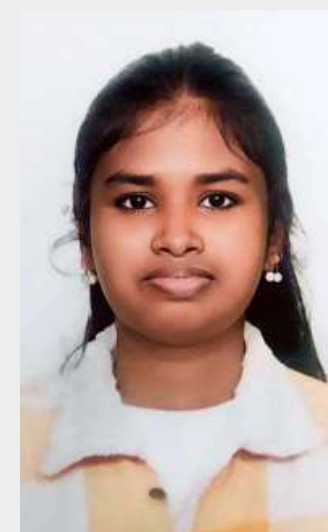
BIRDS READ INVISIBLE MAPS

On World Migratory Bird Day, here is a case study of the Common pochard, exploring possible reasons why this bird could be 'warming up to' birders in the Chennai Metropolitan Area but giving those in Madurai the cold shoulder **P6**



Students with traffic police at the Foreshore Estate signal.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

School topper a beneficiary of RAPRA's free coaching classes



R. CHANDRASEKARAN

Elakkiya R., a student of Rani Meyammai School has emerged as the school topper in the recently announced Plus Two examination results.

Elakkiya, a Commerce group student, secured an impressive 581 marks out of 600. She scored above 90 marks in all subjects and achieved a remarkable 99 in Business Mathematics and Statistics.

Notably, Elakkiya was a beneficiary of the free commerce coaching classes conducted by the RA Puram Residents' Association (RAPRA).

According to the tutors at the RAPRA study centre, she displayed exceptional dedication towards academics, attending classes regularly, actively clarifying doubts and showing consistent enthusiasm for learning. Disciplined preparation and hard work certainly played a major role in her academic success, which also reflects the impact of community-driven educational support initiatives.

(R. Chandrasekaran is a medical doctor and founder of RAPRA)

Mandaveli students swap smartboards for signals

Understanding the challenges faced by traffic police personnel was one of the exercises undertaken by the Sri Chaitanya Techno School as part of a road safety programme which has bagged an award

LIFY THOMAS

Have you fancied being a traffic cop for a few hours? That is what students of Sri Chaitanya Techno School at Norton Road in Mandaveli got to experience last year as the institute enrolled for the National Road Safety Mission for Schools, a pan-India initiative to nudge schools to implement structured road safety programmes that are aimed at reducing road accidents and fatalities through education, awareness and responsible action.

"We wanted to give students a first-hand experience of how the traffic police work and the challenges they face regulating traffic on the road, so we collaborated with the police department and 30 students were given a demonstration.

Later, three students played traffic cop for a couple of hours on the busy road," says Sunitha R, principal, Sri Chaitanya Techno School.

The school is among the Olympiad winners that bagged the National Road Safety Education Excellence Awards 2025-26. The National Road Safety Mission aligns with the United Nations

Sustainable Development Goal 3.6 and includes school zone safety audits, structured K-12 learning modules and a rating framework to assess and improve safety conditions around schools.

In Tamil Nadu, 134 schools took part in the initiative, with five institutions receiving awards and 69 students recognised as Olympiad winners, says a press note.

The principal says the outdoor activity with the police was a big draw among students and many were encouraged to make some difference, starting from their parents on following

road discipline.

Through the 'Smart Living Programme' that the school conducts, it plans to conduct a new activity every month.

"We will be doing more road safety activities the coming academic year as well," says Sunitha.

Other initiatives

From road rally to mass pledges, the school got more than 100 students to appear for a road safety course conducted by National Road Safety Mission (NRSM) for six weeks in January 2026. Rohit S. of Class VIII achieved third rank at the national level road safety olympiad.



From the celebration held on May 2. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



80 glorious years of Vivekananda College

Alumni recall their long association with the institution

The RKMVC Alumni Association celebrated the 80th anniversary of RKM Vivekananda College on May 2, 2026 at the Obul Reddy auditorium of the campus.

Following an informal alumni interaction during which former students reconnected, the formal function commenced. Members of the Core Committee of the Alumni Association were present on the

occasion.

Panchatcharam served as the master of ceremonies, while Ramathan welcomed the dignitaries and the gathering of around 150 alumni members. Swami Dhyana-

gamyandana, secretary of the college, highlighted the significant contributions made by the institution's alumni to several prestigious projects. He sought the alumni's continued support.

T. S. Vijayaraghavan, IAS (retired.), an alumnus of the 1957 batch and guest of honour, fondly recalled how his association with "Viveka" played a crucial role in his success during the IAS interview, said a release.

Ramana, guest of honour and founder chairman and trustee of the ITM Group of Institutions, urged the alumni to carry the college in their hearts. He emphasised that their achievements in diverse fields are deeply rooted in the va-

lues and legacy imparted by their alma mater, which continues to nurture individuals who shine across the globe.

Principal Kumaresan thanked the alumni association and everyone present on behalf of the college management. A light music concert by "Paadarivom Padiparivom" troupe of Shri Naggeswaran, alumnus of the College, who runs it with his father, also an alumnus of the college, was among the highlights. The troupe is known for including differently abled musicians in its group.

Two of the old students also sang. K. Sridhar, alumnus and core committee member, presented the vote of thanks.

Road safety 'dabbed' with a new colour on Santhome High Road



Santhome High Road is known for its institutions. Education is a dominant theme on a given stretch of this road. In the evening hours, around school closing time, one would notice children milling about the road as they head to their bus stops. Some children would have to cross the road before they can get to their bus stop. And on this stretch, despite its narrowness, motorists drive at a clip. Given this reality and children's psychology, what one notices right outside each of the school is a welcome sight, the zebra crossings outside each of the schools combines red stripes with white. It seems like a loud imperative for motorists to slow down as they approach one and for the students to use it. That bright colour cannot be ignored.

EcoKonnectors launches 'Resource Revival Drive'

A community waste collection initiative seeks to revive the resource value of discarded materials



To encourage responsible waste disposal and strengthen community-led sustainability initiatives, EcoKonnectors in partnership with recycling partner SPRECO and residents' welfare associations of R.K. Nagar and Mandaveli Raja Street, is organising "Resource Revival Drive", a community waste collection initiative aimed at reviving the resource value of discarded materials.

The Resource Revival Drive will be held on May 17, 2026 (from 10 a.m. to 4 p.m.) at two collection

points in Chennai. One, RK Nagar Collection Point: Opposite Ananya Apartments, 4/6 Tiruveedhiamman Koil Street, Sringeri Mutt Road, Raja Annamalaipuram. And two, Mandaveli Raja Street Collection Point: Outside Dwaraka Apartment, 21/33 Raja Street, Mandaveli, Raja Annamalaipuram.

The exercise resonates with a battlecry: "Together Let's Revive Resources, Recycle Responsibly, and Renew our Earth!"

A press release from EcoKonnectors notes that by diverting such items from dumping

grounds and extending their life-cycle through recovery and recycling, the initiative seeks to reduce environmental burden. Residents from Mylapore, Mandaveli, Adyar and surrounding neighbourhoods are invited to participate in the drive. The organisers have also positioned the initiative as an opportunity for households to undertake indoor clean-up and decluttering activities during the ongoing summer vacation and heatwave period.

The drive will accept a wide range of dry waste materials including usable clothes, footwear, tailor rags, bedsheets, paired shoes and slippers, metal cans and foil,

glass bottles and jars, toys, stationery, chargers, cables, small electronic items, dry-cell batteries, small electrical items, clean packing thermocol, newspapers, books, cartons, plastic bottles, covers and containers, provided they are clean and dry, says the press release.

Organisers have clarified that mattresses, pillows, broken tube lights, wood and furniture will not be accepted.

Participants have been requested to bring only dry waste materials to the designated collection points and to place items in appropriately labelled bins or cartons. Residents have also been advised not to leave waste outside the col-

lection area or after the designated collection hours.

The press release points out all collected materials will be transported to SPRECO's material recovery facility (MRF) and textile recovery facility (TRF), where they will be processed for reuse and recycling.

The initiative underscores the growing role of citizen participation and neighbourhood-level collaboration in addressing urban waste management challenges.

For further information, residents may contact EcoKonnectors at 7010848668 or 9940056069, and SPRECO at 9150003024 or 9655880250.



During a previous drive.

PLAN YOUR WEEK

Free public speaking workshop

Speak Your Mind, in association with MUN Europe, is organising a free public speaking workshop on May 10, 2026, at Career Launcher, Alwarpet.

Open to students aged 6 to 21, the workshop is designed to help participants build confidence, improve clarity, and learn how to structure their ideas effectively based on their individual personality. Parents are also welcome to attend and watch their children perform.

This initiative aims to create a supportive environment where young speakers can develop essential communication skills that will benefit them academically and beyond.

Students can register online in advance, and spot registrations will also be available at the venue on the day of the event.

For more details and registration,

Contact: 9962194511

Walk to create awareness on multiple sclerosis

To commemorate World Multiple Sclerosis Day (May 30), a walk to create awareness about Multiple Sclerosis will be held on May 14 at Express Avenue between 5 p.m. and 7 p.m.

"Walk In My Shoes" is the campaign slogan.

Multiple sclerosis (MS) is an autoimmune inflammatory demyelinating disease of the central nervous system. Multiple Sclerosis in India is an emerging

neurological concern with an estimated 1.5 to 2 lakh people affected, said a release.

Called crippler of the young adult, it affects people in the age group of 14 to 40, more women than men. Due to low awareness overall, and general lack of knowledge, many patients often delay going to a neurologist. The delayed diagnosis leads to progression as it is a progressive disease, added the release.

Russian Education Fair ends today

The two-day All-India Russian Education Fair for the academic year 2026-2027 will conclude on May 10 at the Russian Centre of Science and Culture in Chennai, 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. Seven leading higher educational institutions, all belonging to the Russian government are taking part, said a release.

Spot admissions for MBBS and other programmes can be made at the fair, which is scheduled to take place also in many locations in Tamil Nadu. For details, call 9282 221 221.

Bootcamp for CLAT 2027

Career Launcher, Chennai, is hosting a three-day CLAT 2027 Bootcamp from May 14-16, focusing on reading, reasoning, and test strategy. This will be held at its centre in Abiramapuram

A GK Quiz for CLAT aspirants will be held on May 17. Open to aspiring lawyers Call/WhatsApp 7550 330 159.

Songs from 'Versatile Asha'



Satrangi's next presentation 'Versatile Asha' will be held on May 10 from 5:45 p.m. at TEACH Auditorium, Taramani.

This programme will feature memorable songs of the iconic singer Asha Bhonsle from movies like *Mere Saanam*, *Don*, *Chhoti Si Baat*, *Jawani Diwani*, *Kismet*, *Umraro Jaan*, *Ijaazat*, *Yaadon Ki Baaraat*, *Kashmir Ki Kali*, *Hum Dono* and *Waqt*.

The programme will be presented by Promod, Ramya, Smriti and Abhishek on pre recorded tracks.

Tickets for this event are priced at ₹500 and ₹300 and will be home delivered on calling 9884778073.

‘Cool hands’ scarce in Chennai

With the mercury shooting up, calls for AC repair experts abound, and many of them go unanswered. A case for making AC technician courses more attractive to youngsters



LIFFY THOMAS

As summer temperatures spike in Chennai, air-conditioner technicians are working overtime, with households and businesses scrambling to install, repair and service cooling systems.

All major service providers note that they are struggling to meet the spurt in demand.

That wheels in a question: is the market being fed with a steady pool of trained AC technicians?

Sundaresan Ranganathan, director, Tamilnadu Advanced Technical Training Institute (TAT-TI), a registered organisation, says the Tamil Nadu Industrial Training Institute started offering a two-year programme in Mechanical Refrigeration and AC in 1985 but the course was discontinued during the pandemic due to poor intake.

Scaled-down versions of the same programme are being offered now, one with a three-month duration, and the other six months, but both struggle to inject sufficient trained technicians into the talent pool.

Polytechnic colleges and service providers have been adapting to attract and retain students and skilled technicians but they



At Ramakrishna Mission Polytechnic College's lab.

have been facing many obstacles. Ramakrishna Mission Polytechnic College in Mylapore, managed by Ramakrishna Mission Students' Home, runs a free residential diploma programme, affiliated to Directorate of Technical Education. At the end of every semester, the college management offers additional training for their students with its training partners, refrigeration and AC course being one of them.

M. Sugumaran, principal of the College, says students are more drawn towards the automobile and manufacturing sector, followed by product design and as developers in the technology sector.

“Diploma students are not so keen on being a technician, preferring to enter the field in supervisory roles for the three-year programme they studied,” says Sugumaran. He says unlike in the past students there have many other alternative courses that show equal, if not greater promise, so becoming a HVAC technician has lost its charm.

Many such institutions admitted students who completed Class X or Class XII; or even dropouts.

According to a report by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) titled ‘Formalising Air Conditioner Technician Training and Certification in India for Climate-resilient Servicing’, the demand for skilled room air-conditioner technicians will rise to around 2 million by 2036-37.

The servicing sector can play a significant role in helping deal with refrigerant overuse for servicing, and bring operational energy-efficiency closer to the designed benchmarks.

For a ready pool of trained technicians, the curriculum offered at most ITI institutions needs a revision. The report says that content must be co-created with industry participation and updated periodically to respond to changes on account of the refrigerant and technology transitions.

In addition to technical training, focus should also be on imparting entrepreneurial and soft skills such as communication and interpersonal skills. Offering social security to informal AC technicians are among other ways to draw people to the HVAC field.

Role of service providers

From incentives to career opportunities, major service providers are adopting different strategies to retain qualified talent.

Hitachi Engineering Excellence Centre runs training programmes to upskill AC technicians with the latest in the field. Its monthly training programmes conducted at SRM Easwari Engineering College in Ramapuram has employees from its 60-plus franchise partners in Tamil Nadu taking part in it.

Besides a skill development centre that Bluestar operates in Ambattur, it runs a training programme on wheels that goes to the doorsteps of the dealers to train technicians in the latest technologies.

Thirst aids for strays

From water bowls placed for thirsty stray animals to coconut shell feeders designed for urban birds, here are two organisations in Chennai finding simple, sustainable ways to help the city's voiceless residents endure the summer



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

As temperatures rise in Chennai during May, the thirst for kindness rises with it. More than ever, the voiceless residents need acts of human kindness to get through their days. A bowl with water or feed is just what the doctor has ordered for animals and birds that are not pets, and have to fend for themselves through the year; and find regular sources of sustenance dry up during peak summer.

Besant Memorial Animal Dispensary (BMAD) in Besant Nagar is step-

ping up once again with its free community water bowl initiative. In its fourth year, the initiative distributes cement water bowls free of cost to residents, community feeders and animal lovers keen on placing them outside homes and shops and in street corners.

The organisation procures the bowls through donations and sponsors, sourcing them from local nurseries and suppliers before distributing them across the city. This year, BMAD initially procured 150 bowls, all of which were claimed within two days.

“We started this because animals

on the streets simply have nowhere to access water,” says Neeraja Venkateswaran, Head of Operations at BMAD. “Natural waterbodies have disappeared or become inaccessible because of urban development. What happens then is that these animals end up suffering from dehydration, heat strokes, and many of them do not survive something as basic as the unavailability of water.”

Where kindness swells, strangely, challenges abound. The logistics is daunting, observes Neeraja.

“And sometimes people ask for larger numbers, but we have to make sure



Bowls kept ready for distribution at BMAD in Besant Nagar.

everyone gets access fairly. Right now, we are distributing a maximum of one bowl per person. We have now placed another order for 400 more.”

The larger concern lies not in distribution, but maintenance. A neglected water bowl can quickly become unhygienic in Chennai's summer heat.

“People should ensure that the water is changed regularly because stagnant water becomes a breeding ground for mosquito larvae,” Neeraja explains. “And if larger animals like cows or horses come there often, it is better to create a permanent water trough because the cement bowls can break.”

The water bowls can be picked up from the BMAD office from Monday to Saturday between 09:30 a.m. and 12:00 p.m., and again from 02:30 p.m. to 04:00 p.m.

Beyond the bowls themselves, Neeraja believes there are countless small acts that can help animals survive the season. These include offering simple meals such as vegetable broth or chicken broth mixed with leftover rice; creating shaded spaces for animals to rest during peak afternoon heat; if possible, allow community dogs to sit inside gated areas or verandahs for some time during extremely hot afternoons.

For further details, BMAD can be contacted via the official email ID: admin.bmadts@gmail.com. They can also be reached through their official Instagram and Facebook handle: @besantmemorialanimaldispensary.

A coconut bowl crafted for feathered residents



A coconut shell bird feeder workshop was organised by Thuvakkam on May 9 at the NGO's head office in Valasaravakkam, bringing together constituencies across demographic divides. The exercise splices urban bird care and sustainable living.

The workshop introduced participants to the process of converting discarded coconut shells into eco-friendly bird feeders.

“Our main aim is to make sure every terrace has an eco-friendly bird feeder so that birds can also survive during summer,” says Kodama Durga Prasad, executive associate – Programs and Volunteering. He added, “Those who do not have space to hang it on their terrace can make use of the urban forests around the city.”

A DIY project

- Take a dry coconut shell and remove all

the inside flesh

- Wash and sun-dry it completely
- Smooth the edges using sandpaper so it is safe for birds
- Make 2-3 small holes near the rim using a drill or heated nail
- Pass jute rope or strong string through the holes and tie secure knots
- Create a loop at the top for hanging
- Optional: Add a small stick across the shell as a perch
- Fill it with millets, rice grains, broken wheat or sunflower seeds
- Avoid salty, spicy or cooked food
- Hang it in a shaded and safe place away from cats
- Refill food regularly and clean the shell once a week to maintain hygiene



During a coconut shell feeder-making session.



sundaravel / Feb 2

Birds read invisible maps

On World Migratory Bird Day, here is a case study of the Common pochard, exploring possible reasons why this bird could be 'warming up to' birders in the Chennai Metropolitan Area but giving those in Madurai the cold shoulder

PRINCE FREDERICK

"Not even time for birds to fly to southern skies." That is a line from Stevie Wonder's "I Just Called To Say I Love You", a song that has stood the shifting fads of time. And that line refers to an avian pattern that has persisted through time. It hints at birds migrating from the north, escaping its inclement winter to sojourn in the south. While the escape will continue winter after winter, the sojourn can undergo changes of address, depending on local factors, anthropogenic and climatic.

Welcome to the choices made by migratory birds: the how and

Common pochards at Amoor Lake near Chennai in February 2026.
PHOTOS: SUNDARAVEL PALANIVEL

why of it.

Dr. T. Badri Narayanan is an ophthalmologist with an eye for birds, an eye sharpened with some degree of formal training (a correspondence course from Bombay Natural History Society and an ornithology course offered by NPTEL during the pandemic) but largely on account of time spent on the field. He illustrates the possible causes of change in bird migration with his observations of the Common pochard in the Chennai Metropolitan Area and his regular stomping ground, Madurai.

Dr. Narayanan notes that the migratory Common pochard is sighted sporadically in the Chennai Metropolitan Area which includes patches of Kancheepuram and Chengalpet. It is also documented from time to time in other parts of southern Tamil Nadu. He recalls sightings of Common pochard flocks around 15 years ago at Aarpakkam tank near Kancheepuram as well as Ponnur lake, also set in the same geography. During the 2025-26 migratory season, the Common pochard showed up as a flock at Amoor lake, near Sirudhavar in Chengalpet district, not too far from Chennai.

In contrast, birders in Madurai are being stood up by this bird.

For anyone who has birded in the 1980s and 90s, this could be startling as Madurai was a sure-fire destination in this bird's winter itinerary. Dr. Badri Narayanan notes that a species can change its wintering address if it is up against habitat degradation. The reality in Madurai does not point in that direction, at least not on the surface, and he looks elsewhere for a possible cause.

He observes that globally, the Common pochard's numbers are dwindling and the species has moved from "Least Concern" to "Near Threatened", and therefore, fewer birds migrate deep into peninsular India. The suggestion is that they could be happily "hot-desked" with enough "seats" provided for them in the wetlands of central and northern India.

A migratory bird might change its wintering address for one or a combination of these reasons. One, habitat destruction. Two, food scarcity. Three, climatic changes. Four, population decline reducing migratory spread (the Common pochard's situation in Madurai probably checks this box). Five, availability of suitable habitats earlier on in their migratory route. Dr. Badri Narayanan notes that a cause can be identified only with sufficient data gathered over a long period of time with observations, around 10 years or more. He points out that citizen-science platforms such as eBird can be source for that kind of data.



Association celebrates Maharashtra day



The Maharashtra Association Chennai celebrated the Chatrapathi Shivaji Jayanthi and Maharashtra day on May 1 at TAG-PSDakshinamurthy auditorium, P S Higher Secondary School in Mylapore. M. Seetharaman, former Head of Department of Physics, University of Madras was honoured with 'Great Maratha

Award'. Three children were honoured with 'Young Maratha awards'. The chief guest was R. Venkataraman, senior advocate. A well appreciated dance production on Marathi saints and Marathi abhangs was presented by dancers of Bharata Natyalaya, under the guidance of the famous dancer, Roja Kannan.

Xpressions marks fourth anniversary with musical fervour

Xpressions, a fast-growing karaoke collective, celebrated its 4th anniversary with a vibrant musical evening at the Music Academy mini hall recently. The event, hosted by Usha Sampath Kumar, drew an enthusiastic audience of over 150 attendees and unfolded as a memorable four-hour showcase of talent and camaraderie.

The programme featured a repertoire of 28 songs spanning timeless classics and contemporary favourites. The performances struck a

chord with the audience, many of whom joined in with spontaneous applause, foot-tapping, and sing-alongs, lending the evening a warm and participative atmosphere, said a release. The organisers have hinted at an upcoming musical event in the near future.

With four successful years behind them, Xpressions continues to grow as a cultural space where passion for music finds expression, and the journey ahead appears set for even greater milestones, added the release.



Workshops on beekeeping and soap making

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre, Guindy, is conducting a workshop on beekeeping on May 14. Another workshop on making herbal soaps will be held on May 15.

According to a press release, participants will learn to make soaps from extracts of flowers, leaves, and fruits. Prior registration is necessary. The sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048.

A cooling effect



Showers on May 8 caught many by surprise. A scene at Egmore.
PHOTO: VELANKANNI RAJ B

Workshop on fundamentals of EV technology

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is conducting a training programme on electrical vehicle technology from May 13 to 15 at its premises EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate in Ekkattuthangal. According to a press release, the concepts covered in the workshop include: basics of power electronics, fundamentals of EV battery, regenerative braking, EV system architecture, electric motors used in EVs and battery management system.

For details, call 8668102600 / 8754495254

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They are staying cool: you can have a cool time visiting them this summer



As temperatures continue to climb, animal keepers at these two iconic parks in Chennai Metropolitan Area can be seen carrying out summer management measures to help captive animals cope with heat stress. Sprinkler systems have been set up across enclosures housing elephants, rhinoceroses, hippopotamuses, chimpanzees and other animals at both Arignar Anna Zoological Park in Vandalur and Guindy Children's Park. These sprinklers are operated multiple times through the day to reduce ambient temperatures and maintain moisture levels inside enclosures. Elephants are given regular showers and allowed to wallow in muddy ponds every day, while primates and bears are provided frozen fruits and meat to help regulate body temperature. Given their biological differences, a slightly different heat-management strategy would obviously be followed for birds.

PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B

Rise in footfall at Chetpet lake



Chetpet lake on April 28, 2026. PHOTO: PRABHU. M

The Chetpet lake-cum-park is witnessing an increase in the number of visitors as it is summer vacation.

It may be noted, this leisure facility, spread across 15.70 acre, was re-

opened during the first week of this March following a renovation carried out by the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority at a cost of ₹20.16 crore, according to a press release dated March 2, 2026.

The work began in June 2025.

As part of the work, the park features musical fountains, outdoor gym, children's play area, and an open gallery with a seating capacity of 120, adds the release.

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